

So and so that

Teaching guide

Distinguish a result from an intended purpose.

Understand the distinction

So commonly introduces a result: I was tired, so I went home. So that commonly introduces a purpose, often with can, could, will, or would: I wrote it down so that I could remember it.

That is sometimes omitted in informal purpose clauses: I wrote it down so I could remember. Use context to decide the meaning. In order to takes a base verb; in order that takes a clause and is more formal. A purpose does not guarantee success.

Compare the patterns

RESULT

The train stopped, so we got off.

Getting off followed the stop.

PURPOSE

I left early so that I could find a seat.

Finding a seat was the goal.

INFINITIVE

I left early in order to find a seat.

The same purpose uses to + verb.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Result or purpose: I spoke slowly so that everyone could follow?

A. A guarantee that everyone understood.

B. Result.

C. Purpose.

2. Choose the correction: I called in order to that I could ask.

A. I called in order that to ask.

B. I called so that I could ask.

C. I called so that ask.

3. Does left early so that I could get a seat prove I got one?

A. Yes. A purpose clause proves success.

B. No. It states a purpose.

C. No. It proves there were no seats.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You left early to catch a bus, but it was full. Which pair separates your purpose from the actual outcome?

A. I left early so that I could catch the bus. It was full, so I waited for the next one.

B. I left early because of I could catch the bus. It was full.

C. I left early so that I could catch the bus. That proves I got on it.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. Purpose.

The speaker intended to help understanding.

A: A purpose does not guarantee the intended result happened.

B: So that everyone could follow states the speaker's aim.

2. B. I called so that I could ask.

Alternatively: I called in order to ask.

A: Use either in order to ask or so that I could ask.

C: So that normally introduces a clause with a subject and verb.

3. B. No. It states a purpose.

The intended result may not have happened.

A: The clause states the aim; it does not establish the actual result.

C: The outcome is not stated either way.

4. A. I left early so that I could catch the bus. It was full, so I waited for the next one.

So that gives the aim; so introduces the consequence of the bus being full.

B: Because of does not introduce a full clause.

C: A purpose clause does not prove success, and the stated outcome says you did not board.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-30.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

You left early to catch a bus, but it was full. Which pair separates your purpose from the actual outcome?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.